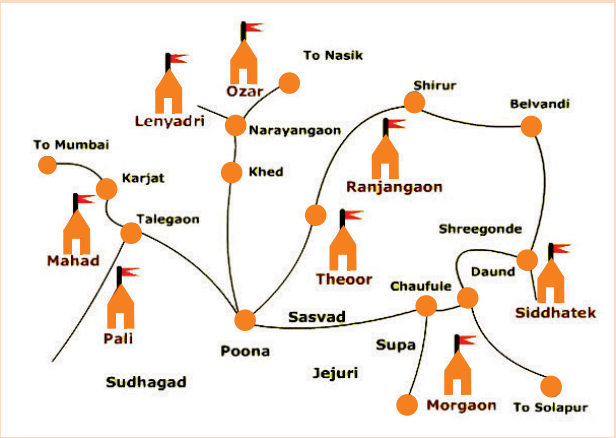

MAHALKXMI MANDIR, KOLHAPUR


GRISHNESHWAR TEMPLE, LEFT SIDE VIEW

a visit to Panchavati and the ancient **Kalaram Mandir** located there.

Close by **Trimbakeshwar** is the site of one of the holiest Jyotirling. The Shivalinga here has three faces representing the triumvirate of Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshwara. A must visit for all Shiva devotees, it is believed that people can rid themselves of Kalasarpa and Pitru doshas or curses afflicting them, by performing pooja here. The holy Godavari originates from the hills surrounding Trimbakeshwar.



Bhimashankar, near to Pune, hosts another Jyotirlinga. Devotees take a dip in the Bhima river and worship him as Ardhanariswara. The site of his battle and subsequent victory over Tripurasura, the river is believed to have its origins from the lord's sweat. Hence, bathing in it, rids one of their sins.

Grishneshwar, nearer to Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, brings up the last of the Jyotirlingas. However, it is believed that having darshan here bestows one of the blessings of all the Jyotirlingas.

The pilgrimage to the Shivakshetras in Maharashtra is complete only with a visit to the ancient temples of **Aundha Naganath,** believed to be constructed by Yudhisthira and the legendary Parli Vaijnath, where the Shivalinga has great healing powers. At Jejuri, Shiva transforms into a local deity to enjoy the devotion of the faithful. Khandoba is a clan god for many Maharashtrian castes and communities, beloved as a god who grants wishes.

Shri Jyotiba Temple on the hills at Wadi Ratnagiri near Kolhapur celebrates the hindu triumvirate of Bramha, Vishnu, Mahesh who incarnated together as the deity Jyotiba to destroyed the evil Ratnasura.

With celebrations spanning across Eleven days, the Ganesha Festival erupts into a huge revelry across the state. It is a great time to visit the state to witness the perfect blend of fervor, pomp, pageantry and public bonhomie. The entire state host its favorite deity across households and public sarvajanik pandals. It is no wonder then that the most auspicious temples of Ganesh are present in the state. The famed **Ashtavinayak Pilgrimage** takes one through the districts of Raigad, Pune and Ahmednagar. Covering eight temples in 3 days and 2 nights, it starts at the temple of **Morgaon,** the abode of Lord Mayureshwar in Pune District and ends there. The next stop is at **Siddhatek** in Ahmednagar.

Present as Siddhivinayak, he bestows spiritual powers to his devotees. The journey next winds its way to **Pali** in Raigad District. Lording over it as Ballaleshwar, the morning rays of the sun pay their homage to the idol. The next shrine is 38kms away in Mahad. The Varadvinayak fulfills the wishes of the devotees who chant his name. The Nandadeep that fills the temple by its glow, adds lustre to his sentient presence.

Theur in Pune District houses Chintamani, promising peace and freedom from worries. The next stop is at **Lenyadri.** Finding mention in the Ganesha Purana, the entire temple is carved out of a single stone. The Girijatmaja faces the east and has his trunk turned to the left. At **Ozar,** the Vighneshwar Vinayak presides over as the destroyer of the demon Vighneshwar. **Ranjangoan** bring up the rear of this spiritual journey. The Mahaganapati here is believed to have aided his father in combating and killing the evil Tripurasura. The rays of the sun fall on the idol here, adding to his aura.

Apart from these Mumbai boasts of the much revered **Siddivinayak Temple,** while Pune claims its quota of spirituality with the **DagaduSheth Halwai Mandir.** Both of them are considered to be amongst the richest temples of India. Moving a bit down south, on the shores of the Arabian sea, the svayambhu idol of Ganesha rules over **Ganpatipule,** firmly nailing its place on the spiritual map of Maharashtra.

Maharashtra is home to **Shaktipeeths** too. The manifestation of power from which creation ensures, it is always celebrated in the form of the mother. The **Mahalakshmi Temple** at Kolhapur, The **Renuka Devi Temple** at Mahurgad, The **Bhavani Temple** in Tuljapur and the **Saptashrungi Temple** at Wani make up this cluster.

A spiritual journey across Maharashtra will not be complete without paying homage to the religious gurus who have instilled the bhakti movement in the state. Foremost amongst them is Sant Dnyaneshwar, a 13th-century Indian Marathi saint, poet, philosopher and yogi. His Dnyaneshwari, a commentary on the Bhagavad Gita and Amrutanubhav are the oldest surviving literary works in the Marathi language.

He undertook samadhi at **Alandi** in 1296 by entombing himself in an underground chamber. **Akkalkot** is a Holy place of ShriSwami Samarth Maharaj, believed to be the reincarnation of Lord Dattatraya. The Samadhi of this Saint is worshipped by the devotees. **Shegaon** houses the samadhi of the revered spiritual teacher Shri Gajanan Maharaj. The temple complex has emerged as an important pilgrimage place. Shirdi is home to Shri Sai Baba's samadhi mandir. Every day, over 60,000 tourists and devotees from all faiths and religions throng to the temple.

We invite you to embark on pilgrimage across Maharashtra. It could well turn out to be the journey of self-discovery!